

31% foreign now, 38% by 2030?

*Testing PwC Malta's figures for foreign residents
against Eurostat, NSO and Jobsplus data*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“...foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta's population ... with the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030.”

PwC Malta, Summer 2026 Economic Update press release, as published by The Malta Business Weekly, 19 July 2026.
Two paragraphs of one release; the 2030 figure comes from PwC's own model.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

31% right; 38% by 2030 not shown

Version 1.0 · 6 October 2026

Status: right of reply on hold until PwC's report is read

Prepared from public sources and official statistics.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

PwC Malta’s press release on its *Summer 2026 Economic Update* (The Malta Business Weekly, 19 July 2026) says: “**The latest figures show that foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population**”, with “**the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030.**” We tested both figures against Eurostat, NSO and Jobsplus data.

- 1

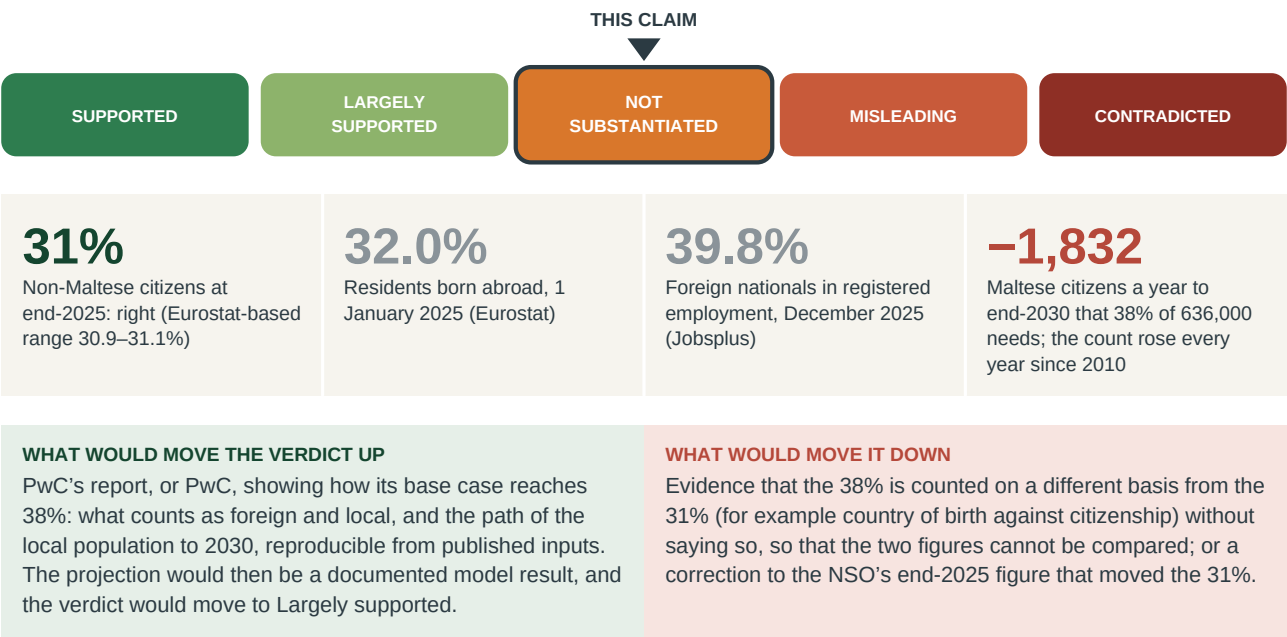
The 31% is right. The NSO reports 31.1% non-Maltese citizens at the end of 2025 (as reported by news outlets ♦); Eurostat’s own figures give 30.9–31.1%.
- 2

The definition matters. 32.0% of residents were born abroad already on 1 January 2025, and foreign nationals held 39.8% of registered jobs in December 2025 (Jobsplus).
- 3

The 38% is PwC’s own projection. Eurostat’s projections do not split Malta’s future population by citizenship, we found no NSO projection that does, and PwC’s report, which sets out its model, could not be read.
- 4

On the same definition, it does not follow from PwC’s base case. 38% of 636,000 leaves 394,320 local residents: 1,832 fewer Maltese citizens a year to the end of 2030. Their number rose every year 2010–2024, and what was left after naturalisations and migration fell by at most 1,441 a year (2021–2024).
- 5

Verdict: not substantiated (moderate confidence). Today’s figure is right; the 2030 figure has not been shown. It could fit another definition (country of birth), which the release does not mention.



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1 The claim and what we could verify

The words are PwC Malta’s. The Malta Business Weekly published them on 19 July 2026 as a press release about PwC’s *Summer 2026 Economic Update* [1]; the same text appears on the Malta Chamber’s website (22 July) [2] and on Mondaq, under PwC’s name (23 July) [3]. The release speaks of “our projections” and quotes PwC Malta’s Territory Senior Partner, so we assess it as PwC’s statement. The two figures are in different paragraphs of the same release.

What PwC says	Where	Access
“Malta’s population reached 588,254 by year-end 2025. This marks an increase of approximately 14,000 residents (2.4%) from the previous year.”	Press release, para. 1 [1–3]	Read in full, 6 Oct 2026
“The latest figures show that foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population, with net migration patterns continuing to drive growth.”	Para. 2 [1–3]	Read in full; no source or definition given
“Based on PwC’s demographic modelling, Malta’s population is projected to reach a base case of 636,000 by 2030.”	Para. 2 [1–3]	Read in full
“Our projections are based on varying levels of slowdown in current net migration flows. Nonetheless, population is still expected to increase significantly, with the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030.”	Para. 6 [1–3]	Read in full; method in the report
The <i>Summer 2026 Economic Update</i> itself, which “sets out demographic projections”	pwc.com [4]	Not readable: 403 to scripts; no Internet Archive capture
◆ Quoted by two outlets as the report’s words: “... the results suggest that population would still increase significantly, with the mix of foreign to local reaching around 38% in the base case.” Range 624,000–660,000.	Business Now [5], Newsbook [6]	Second-hand

The record’s link. Our intake record pointed to a different Malta Business Weekly article (2 June 2025, by Silvan Mifsud, on a Central Bank of Malta policy note) [21]. That article does not contain the claim: it gives 28.1% of the population as foreign nationals in 2023 and “just over 31%” of the working-age population. The claim’s wording matches the July 2026 release, which we rate here.

SCOPE NOTE

This check tests two statistics and how they were produced. It does not assess migration policy, the economic effects of population growth, or the hospital-bed and electricity figures in the same release. The words “foreign” and “local” are PwC’s; we use the statistical terms (non-Maltese citizens, born abroad) when we test them.

2 Method

Questions. (1) Were foreign residents 31% of Malta’s population at the time of the release, and on what definition? (2) Does “around 38% by 2030” come from a published projection, and does it follow from published figures?

Evidence. We downloaded from Eurostat’s dissemination API on 6 October 2026, with Eurostat’s flags: the population on 1 January by citizenship and by country of birth [10, 11], the demographic balance [12], Census 2021 [13], immigration, emigration and acquisitions of citizenship by citizenship [14], births by the mother’s citizenship and deaths by citizenship [15], and the EUROPOP2025 projections [16]. We downloaded Jobsplus’s workbooks on foreign nationals in employment and total employment [18, 19]. The NSO’s release of 11 July 2026 [7] and PwC’s report [4] refused automated access; their figures are used only as reported by news outlets, marked ◆. The Central Bank of Malta’s policy note was read as its abstract (Crossref) [20]. Every figure is recomputed by `tools/cc-099-report/calc.py` from `data/cc-099/`. A Crossref search (three queries, logged in

literature/CC-099/notes.md) found no peer-reviewed study of Malta's foreign-population share or its projection.

Definitions. Eurostat counts usual residents (a stay of at least 12 months, or intended to last that long); citizenship is the legal bond with a state, and a non-national is a citizen of another country or stateless [17]. The population on 1 January of a year is the population at the end of the year before: Eurostat's 1 January 2026 total is 588,254, the figure PwC gives for the end of 2025 [1, 12].

Grades. Official statistics and administrative data are grade C under our scale. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3

What “foreign residents” can mean

The release does not define “foreign residents”. Three published measures fit the phrase, and they differ by several points (Figure 1, Table 1). Counted by **citizenship**, a person born in Malta to foreign parents is foreign, and a foreigner who becomes a Maltese citizen is not. Counted by **country of birth**, Maltese citizens born abroad are included. Jobsplus counts **foreign nationals in employment**, a share of jobs, not of residents.

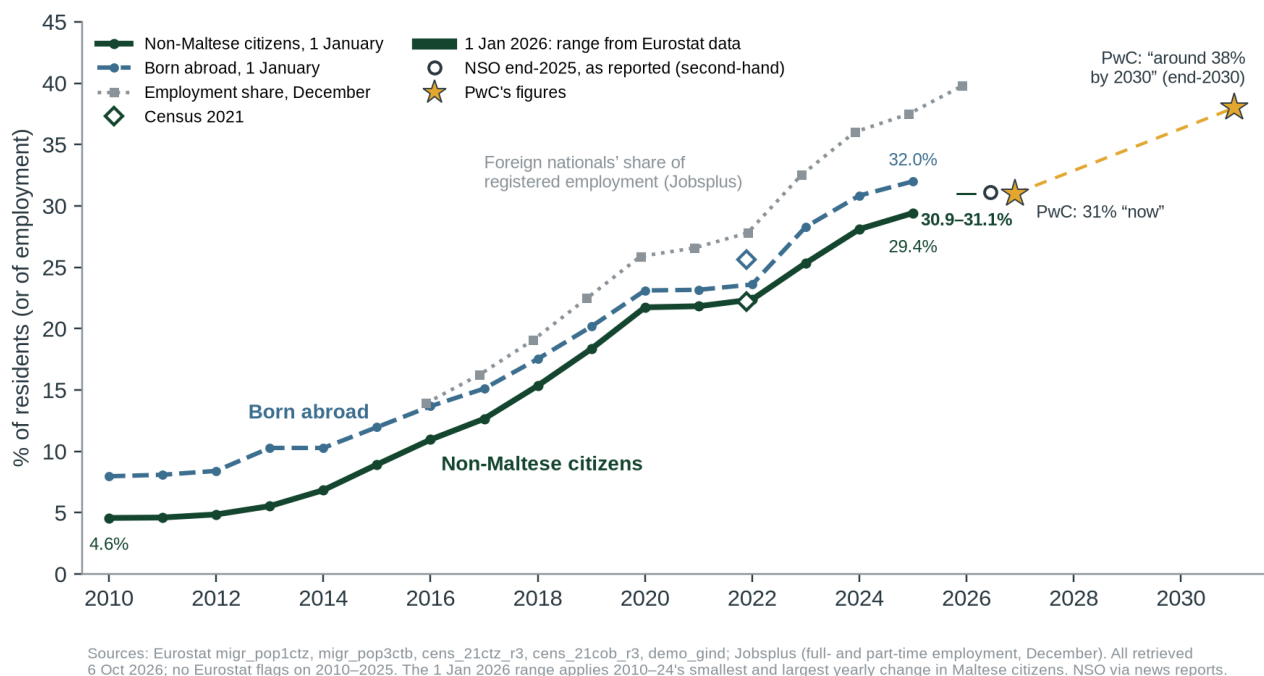


Figure 1. Share of Malta's residents who are non-Maltese citizens and who were born abroad (Eurostat, 1 January), and foreign nationals' share of registered employment (Jobsplus, December). Census 2021 (reference date 21 November 2021 [22]) is shown as diamonds. The green bar at 1 January 2026 is the range given by Eurostat's own figures (section 4); the hollow circle is the NSO's end-2025 figure as reported ♦. PwC's 38% is plotted at the end of 2030.

Measure	Value	Date	Source	Grade
Non-Maltese citizens (other EU 8.0%, non-EU 21.4%)	29.4% (168,938)	1 Jan 2025	Eurostat [10]	C
◆ Non-Maltese citizens, NSO	31.1% (182,693)	end-2025	NSO via news [8, 9]	C
Non-Maltese citizens, range from Eurostat figures	30.9–31.1%	1 Jan 2026	calculated [10, 12]	C
Born abroad	32.0% (183,765)	1 Jan 2025	Eurostat [11]	C
Census: non-Maltese citizens / born abroad	22.2% / 25.7%	21 Nov 2021	Eurostat [13]	C
Foreign nationals in employment (full- and part-time)	39.8% (135,417)	Dec 2025	Jobsplus [18, 19]	C
Foreign nationals in full-time employment	42.2%	Dec 2025	Jobsplus [18, 19]	C

Table 1. All values in data/cc-099/checks.csv. Eurostat’s 2010–2025 citizenship and birth series carry no flags; earlier years carry a break (2001, 2009) and an estimate (2006). The employment shares are of registered jobs and are not comparable with shares of residents.

4 Testing the 31%

The latest year for which Eurostat publishes Malta’s population by citizenship is 1 January 2025: 29.4% non-Maltese citizens, up from 28.1% a year earlier and 4.6% in 2010 [10]. PwC’s “latest figures” refer to the end of 2025, a year later. Eurostat already gives that total, 588,254 on 1 January 2026, matching PwC’s figure and its 14,004 rise (2.44%) in 2025 [12].

Without the citizenship split for 2026 we cannot read the share directly, but we can bound it. The number of Maltese citizens rose in every year from 2010 to 2024, by between 237 (2024) and 1,394 (2011) a year [10]. If 2025’s change lay anywhere in that range, Maltese citizens numbered 405,549–406,706 on 1 January 2026, and non-Maltese citizens were **30.9–31.1%** of 588,254. Both ends round to 31%.

The NSO’s own figure agrees. Its World Population Day release (11 July 2026) is not readable from our network, but four outlets report it: 68.9% Maltese citizens and 31.1% non-Maltese citizens at the end of 2025, or 182,693 people [8, 9] ◆. That implies 405,561 Maltese citizens, 249 more than a year earlier, inside the range above. PwC does not name its source; the 31% matches the NSO’s citizenship figure, rounded (our identification). By country of birth the share would be higher: 32.0% were born abroad a year earlier [11].

5 Testing the 38% by 2030

Is it an official projection?

No. Eurostat’s EUROPOP2025 projections (June 2026) give Malta’s population by age and sex only, with no split by citizenship or country of birth [16]. The Central Bank of Malta wrote in May 2025 that it projected the native Maltese population itself “in the absence of demographic projections specifically covering the native Maltese population” [20]. The NSO’s website refuses automated access, and a web search found no NSO projection by citizenship; Newsbook reports a parliamentary reply that the government holds “no formal projections for population growth in any of the next four years” ◆ [6]. The 38% is PwC’s own model result: the release attributes it to “our projections”, based on “varying levels of slowdown in current net migration flows” [1].

What “38%” means

“The mix of foreign to local residents” could be read as a ratio of foreign to local. On 1 January 2025 there were already 41.7 non-Maltese citizens for every 100 Maltese citizens [10], so a ratio of 38 would be a fall, which the

release does not describe. We read the 38% as a share of all residents, as the 31% is.

What it requires

At PwC's base case of 636,000 residents, 38% foreign means 241,680 foreign and 394,320 local residents. On the citizenship definition behind the 31%, local residents are Maltese citizens: 405,312 on 1 January 2025 [10]. Reaching 394,320 by the end of 2030 means 10,992 fewer, a fall of **1,832 a year** for six years (2,198 a year if “by 2030” means its start). Figure 2 sets that against what has happened.

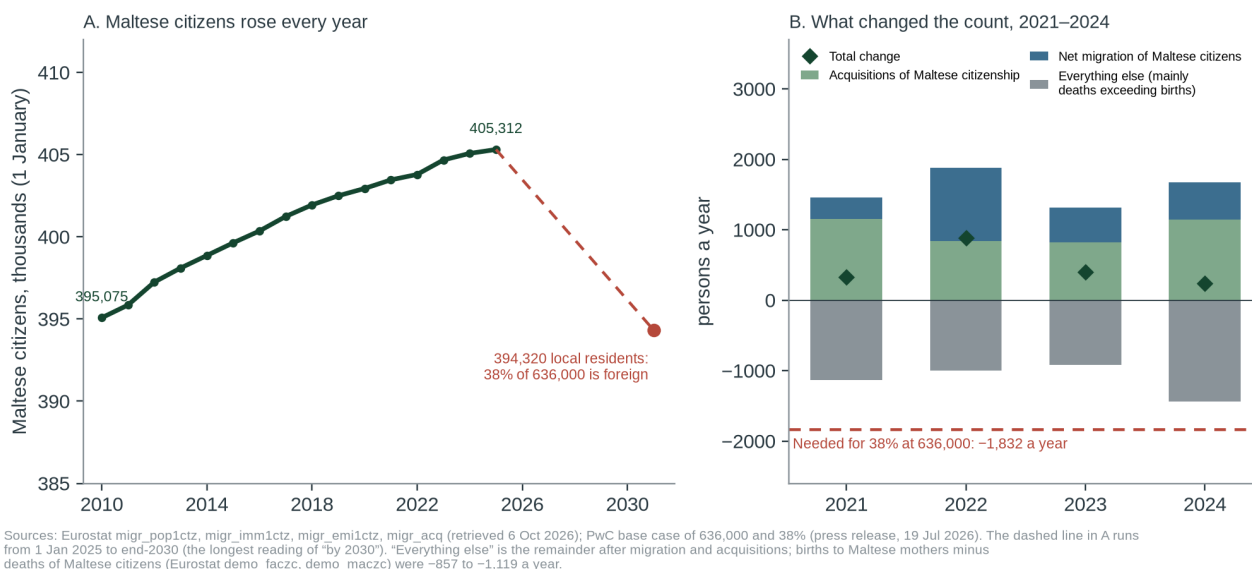


Figure 2. A: Maltese citizens on 1 January, 2010–2025, and the number that 38% of 636,000 leaves for local residents. B: the parts of each year's change, 2021–2024: acquisitions of Maltese citizenship, net migration of Maltese citizens, and the remainder [10, 14, 15].

Year	Total change	Net migration of Maltese	Acquisitions of citizenship	Remainder	Births to Maltese mothers minus deaths of Maltese
2021	+331	+306	+1,156	-1,131	-900
2022	+881	+1,039	+842	-1,000	-921
2023	+400	+489	+825	-914	-857
2024	+237	+533	+1,145	-1,441	-1,119
Needed for 38% of 636,000	-1,832 a year				

Table 2. Maltese citizens, components of change (persons). Remainder = total change minus net migration and acquisitions; it also includes losses of citizenship and statistical adjustment. Births are counted by the mother's citizenship, which can differ from the child's (general context), so the last column is approximate. Eurostat [10, 14, 15]; acquisitions for 2010 carry a break flag (not used).

Even if no foreigner became a Maltese citizen and no Maltese citizen moved in or out, the remainder alone fell by 914–1,441 a year in 2021–2024, a slower fall than the 1,832 needed. For comparison only: had the number of Maltese citizens stayed at its 1 January 2025 level, they would be 63.7% of 636,000, leaving 36.3% foreign. The release gives no local-population path; Business Now reports the report as describing the local population as having “remained at just over 400,000” ♦ [5].

Two readings would give about 38%. On **country of birth**, 390,485 residents were born in Malta on 1 January 2025 [11]; at that level they would be 61.4% of 636,000, so 38.6% would be born abroad. And at the top of PwC's reported range, 660,000 ♦ [5, 6], today's number of Maltese citizens would leave 38.6% non-Maltese. The release says neither. Its 31% matches the citizenship count, so a 38% on another basis would not be comparable with it.

Context: total population

PwC’s base case sits between Eurostat’s projections. EUROPOP2025 gives 621,470 on 1 January 2030 and 628,876 on 1 January 2031 in its baseline, and 650,230 and 663,463 with higher migration [16]. Its baseline for 1 January 2026 (585,012) was already 3,242 below the outcome [12, 16]. We do not rate the 636,000; it is the denominator PwC chose.

6 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Could the local population fall fast enough for 38%?

NOT ON RECENT FIGURES

EVIDENCE THAT THE LOCAL POPULATION COULD FALL
The Central Bank of Malta projects “a persistent decline and ageing of the native Maltese population” [20]. Amphora Media reports that the note leaves out people who acquire citizenship ♦ [23]. Births to Maltese mothers have been below deaths of Maltese citizens in every year 2021–2024 [15]. A model that left out naturalisations would show the local count falling.

EVIDENCE AGAINST
The number of Maltese citizens rose in every year 2010–2024 [10]. In 2021–2024, 825–1,156 people a year became Maltese citizens and net migration of Maltese citizens was positive [14]. Even with both set to zero, the remainder fell by at most 1,441 a year, short of the 1,832 needed (Table 2).

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE
For this claim: the release gives no assumption for the local population, so the reader cannot tell which path PwC used. Only the report could show it, and we could not read it.

Q2 Is the 38% on the same definition as the 31%?

UNKNOWN

EVIDENCE OF ONE DEFINITION
The release uses one phrase for both (“foreign residents”; “the mix of foreign to local residents”) and gives no change of definition. The 31% matches the NSO’s citizenship figure (section 4).

EVIDENCE THAT A DIFFERENT BASIS FITS
On country of birth the arithmetic gives about 38.6% at 636,000 with today’s number of Malta-born residents [11], close to PwC’s figure. That reading would fit the 38% but not the 31% (32.0% were born abroad a year earlier).

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE
For this claim: either the 38% is on the citizenship basis and needs an unexplained fall in Maltese citizens, or it is on another basis and cannot be set beside the 31%. Both mean the figure has not been shown.

7 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. “foreign residents now make up 31% of Malta’s population”	Eurostat-based range 30.9–31.1% of non-Maltese citizens on 1 January 2026; 29.4% a year earlier [10, 12]. The NSO’s 31.1% agrees ♦ [8]. By country of birth the share is higher (32.0% in 2025) [11].	ACCURATE
B. “the mix of foreign to local residents potentially reaching around 38% by 2030”	PwC’s own model; no Eurostat or NSO projection by citizenship found [16, 20]. At PwC’s 636,000 it needs Maltese citizens to fall by 1,832 a year; they rose every year 2010–2024, and without naturalisations or migration fell by at most 1,441 a year [10, 14]. Report not readable [4].	NOT SUBSTANTIATED
C. “Malta’s population reached 588,254 by year-end 2025 ... approximately 14,000 residents (2.4%)” (context)	Eurostat: 588,254 on 1 January 2026; +14,004 (2.44%) in 2025 [12].	ACCURATE

The verdict rests on A and B, the two figures in the claim. C is the release’s own context and is rated for completeness.

8

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The 31% is right. The 38% by 2030 is PwC's own model result; on the same definition it does not follow from PwC's base case, and its method could not be read. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) The current figure reproduces from Eurostat's data and matches the NSO's. (2) The 2030 figure is not an official projection, and the release gives only one sentence on how it was made. (3) On the citizenship basis of the 31%, 38% of PwC's 636,000 requires the number of Maltese citizens to fall faster than any recent figures show; on another basis it cannot be compared with the 31%. (4) The release hedges the figure ("potentially", "around") but presents it as the result of its projections without the inputs a reader would need, and the inputs we could check point lower: more than the evidence offered shows. (5) Confidence is moderate: the NSO's end-2025 figure is second-hand, and PwC's report, which may explain the 38%, could not be read.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that the share of foreign residents will not rise, that PwC's population total is wrong, or anything about migration policy. It addresses only whether the two figures are supported by the evidence offered and available.

Right of reply. A reply from PwC Malta is on hold until its *Summer 2026 Economic Update* is read, because the explanation of the 38% may be in it. If the report shows the method, the verdict will be revisited before any reply is sought.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The definition of "foreign" and "local" behind the 38%: citizenship, as in the 31%, or country of birth.
- ☐ The base-case number of local residents for 2030, and the assumptions for births, deaths, migration and naturalisations that produce it.
- ☐ The share of foreign residents at the low (624,000) and high (660,000) ends of PwC's range.
- ☐ From the NSO: the end-2025 population by citizenship as a published table (Eurostat's 1 January 2026 split was not yet available on 6 October 2026).

9

Limitations

- PwC's report could not be read (pwc.com refuses automated access and the Internet Archive has no copy); it may explain the 38%.
- The NSO's end-2025 figures are second-hand (nso.gov.mt refuses automated access; an Internet Archive copy exists but could not be opened from our network). Four outlets agree, and Eurostat's own data bound the share to 30.9–31.1%.
- The bound in section 4 uses the range of yearly changes in 2010–2024; 2025's change is not yet published by Eurostat.
- The Central Bank of Malta's note was read as its abstract; its 2030 figures for the native population are not used.
- Births are recorded by the mother's citizenship, so the last column of Table 2 is approximate.
- Jobsplus counts registered jobs, not people or residents; its shares are not comparable with population shares.
- Figures quoted from the report by Business Now and Newsbook are second-hand (♠) and decide no rating.

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Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	6 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply to PwC Malta on hold until its Summer 2026 Economic Update is read.